gave him the ultimate creative freedom. It allowed him to shed the heavy burden of legacy and traditional expectations. He grew his hair long, rocked a goatee, rebelled by playing the sitar standing up, and eventually came to a point where he was comfortable being who he is—a classical musician.

Now, whether he is bridging the gap between classical ragas and mainstream pop, or collaborating with western music giants, he is not afraid to push the envelope. "You will garner some criticism on the way, but let's face it, you will garner some criticism anyway. So, why not take risks and do what your heart really desires?" he says. One of his most ambitious works to date, *Unbounded (Abaad)* (2021), traverses multiple genres, including jazz, Latin, folk, Sufi, country and Hindustani classical music, and features Indian and international musicians. "I believe it is very important to build these bridges across genres and countries, especially in today's divided times," he says.

Chatterjee is also working closely with actor Farhan Akhtar for his Hollywood debut in the Beatles biopic where Akhtar portrays the sitar maestro Pandit Ravi Shankar. He is clearly impressed by Akhtar's ability to pick up the nuances of the sitar quickly, owing to the fact that the actor is also a musician and plays the guitar. "He asked me to show him how to play 'Sa Re Ga Ma' on the sitar only twice and he almost got it right," he smiles, adding that they have been constantly exchanging notes on WhatsApp. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

The **Saath Saath** *tour will travel across six cities: Kolkata (May 30), Delhi (Jun. 6), Surat (Jun. 13), Nagpur (Jun. 20), Chennai (Jun. 27) and Mumbai (Jun. 28)*

CINEMA ▼

Once More, With Pride

WHAT TO LOOK OUT FOR AT THE 17TH EDITION OF THE **KASHISH PRIDE FILM FESTIVAL** IN MUMBAI

It is fitting that South Asia's biggest queer film festival, held in India, is called Kashish. This Urdu word, meaning 'charm', captures the spirit of breaking out of binaries and exploring the world in all its colour and vigour. The 17th edition, Kashish 2026, will be held in Mumbai from June 3 to 7, featuring 153 films from 43 countries, including 57 in competition. "Starting this year, we have curated a short films package—'Programmers' Pick'—for films that slipped through the cracks of competition, but not our attention," says founder-team member Saagar Gupta. "My personal favourites are *Chico* and *Linger*."

Among this year's buzzy titles is *Sabar Bonda*, Rohan Kanawade's directorial debut, which won the Grand Jury Prize at the 2025 Sundance Film Festival. The Marathi feature follows an urban man returning to his village, where he develops a homoerotic bond with a childhood friend. Then there's *Queering India*, an Australian-Indian production by Lakhinandan Boruah and Swapnesh Dubey. Set against the backdrop of the Supreme Court declining to legalise same-sex marriage, the documentary traces Dubey's coming-out journey. Another documentary is Sam Feder's *Heightened Scrutiny*, which follows civil rights lawyer Chase Strangio as he fights for transgender adolescents' access to gender-affirming healthcare in the US.



BUZZY PICKS John Lithgow and Olivia Colman in *Jimpa*; (top) a still from *Sabar Bonda*



MARK DE BLOK

The festival opens with *Jimpa*, directed by Sophie Hyde and starring John Lithgow as a gay man living freely in Amsterdam. His filmmaker daughter (Olivia Colman) visits him, hoping to bridge generational gaps and also make a feature film on him. Closing the festival is the Spanish drama *Maspalomas*, centred on another elderly gay man. Also among the special features is Dibakar Banerjee's *LSD 2*, an edgy excursion into queer lives.

While Sridhar Rangayan, founder-director of the festival is not partial to any selection, he does have two recommendations. "*The Crowd* (Iran) is a brave film produced underground," he says. "And *On the Road* (Mexico) is a raw, sexy film about the struggles of a lonely boy wandering through truck stops and getting involved in drugs, sex and murders." That is Kashish in all its colour and vigour. ■

—Devarsi Ghosh

The screenings will be held from Jun. 3-7 at Liberty Cinema, Alliance Française and NGMA, Mumbai